giving his first interview in nearly twenty years, declared the 1968 Soviet-led invasion that ousted him would have been ‘unthinkable’ had Gorbachev been in power then.

For two decades, Honecker blotted out the memory of the man connected with the ‘Prague Spring’, but now – splashed on the front page of the Italian communist daily L’Unita – Dubček complained of being pushed to the margins of society, working as a forestry official and monitored under police surveillance until Gorbachev visited Prague in 1987. ‘After that, I didn’t see the police anymore,’ Dubček gushed, referring to his newly found freedom.

Equally perplexing was the call of a Moscow weekly for the restoration of citizenship to dissident Alexander Solzhenitsyn. In an unblushingly frank leader, the paper lauded a ‘remarkable son of Russia’, who should not have been expelled in 1974. An outspoken critic of communism, Solzhenitsyn had helped to raise international awareness of political repression and the dehumanising Gulag system. Honecker, himself, proved unforgiving to his own party comrades seeking rehabilitation. He ignored Konrad Naumann’s (the drunken coupist) appeals for a second chance. ‘I feel that at 58 years of age, I am able and ready to meet other party duties,’ Naumann pleaded in vain – he was never destined to recover office.8

Throughout that winter, Honecker continued to gaze West. He succeeded in boosting the GDR’s international legitimacy with a three-day visit to France where he was feted by President Francois Mitterrand. In Paris, the two agreed that the superpowers should halve their nuclear arsenals but differed on calls for a freeze on short-range missiles. Honecker also referred to a GDR proposal for a chemical-weapon-free zone in Central Europe but said a global ban ‘would of course be even better’.9 In a front-page commentary, Le Monde said the visit was a result of ‘normalisation of relations between East Germany and Western Europe’. Toasting Honecker at the Elysee Palace, Mitterrand pronounced that Europe ‘must not be the mute witness or the passive prize of East-West relations’, and the occasion showed the desire for reconciliation between ‘the French and the Germans, all the Germans, wherever they find themselves’. The only low point came when the Prime Minister, Jacques Chirac, said he hoped the Berlin Wall would